anonymously in 1888, but contained more about Restoration theatre history than about the actor; this was also true of Robert Lowe's *Thomas Betterton* of 1891, though his work has remained the standard reference on the player. As of 1972, no full-dress modern biography has been published.

The Garrick Club has a portrait of Betterton by Kneller or his studio, and two Knellers have been reported at Knole, one of them dated 1708 and showing the actor in his own hair. The National Portrait Gallery has a painting of Betterton from the studio of Kneller dating about 1690–1700. A copy of a Kneller, once attributed to Alexander Pope though possibly the work of Jervas, belongs to the Earl of Mansfield. R. Williams made a mezzotint after one of the Knellers (they are similar), and engravings of it were done by R. B. Parkes, W. Evans, J. Wooding, M. Van der Gucht, E. W. Alais, J. B. Allen, and Geoffrey. A pastel by Greenhill done about 1663, supposedly picturing Betterton as Bajazet (a role he is not known to have played), is in the Bankes collection, Kingston Lacy. Two other portraits of the actor were in the Betterton sale of 1710; one showed him with bayes on his head, and a second was willed by Mrs Betterton to Frances Williamson. The Victoria and Albert Museum has a small portrait of the actor which is a variant of the Kneller. A frontispiece in Rowe's *Shakespeare* of 1709 pictures Hamlet, Gertrude, and the Ghost, and supposedly represents Betterton, Mrs Barry, and possibly Barton Booth. Of all the portraits, the one in the National Portrait Gallery is perhaps the most telling and captures that piercing glance and commanding air that made Thomas Betterton the greatest actor of his time.

**Betterton, Mrs Thomas, Mary, née Saunderson** *c. 1637–1712, actress.*

Mary Saunderson's birthdate and parentage are somewhat obscure, but since she was a spinster of about 25 when she married in December 1662, she was probably born about 1637. Her origins may have been humble; her widowed mother's Christian name was not given on Mary's marriage allegation, and she had it attested by Enoch Darrack of St Pancras, Soper Lane, a grocer. Of her childhood, nothing is known.

She is said to have acted before her marriage at the Red Bull and reputedly was the first professional actress on the English stage, but this reputation cannot be corroborated. She was certainly one of the earliest, however, and her initial roles would suggest the possibility of some previous acting experience. At some point she joined Sir William Davenant's players, probably in 1660, and she was one of four actresses who boarded at Davenant's lodgings in a wing of the converted tennis court in Lincoln's Inn Fields that Sir William used as a playhouse.

Miss Saunderson's first recorded appearance was as Ianthe (which Pepys used as a pet name for her thereafter) in Davenant's *The Siege of Rhodes* when it was produced in its expanded two-part version by the Duke's Company on 28 and 29 June 1661. On 24 August she played Ophelia to Thomas Betterton's Hamlet, the first of several Shakespearean roles for which she became famous. The first role assigned her as Mrs Betterton, according to the prompter Downes, was Aurelia in *The Cutter of Coleman Street* on 16 December 1661 at Lincoln's Inn Fields. Though the records are woefully incomplete, during the following twelve months she played Juliet (1 March 1662), Cleora in *The Bondman* (2 April), the title role in *The Duchess of Malfi* (30 September), Bellmont in *The Villain* (18 October), and an unidentified role in *The Valiant Cid* (1 December)—before getting married. On 22 October 1662 Pepys recorded in his *Diary* that Benier (his barber?) "who being acquainted with all the players, do tell me that Better-

ton is not married to Ianthe, as they say; but also that he is a very sober, serious man, and studious and humble."

The sober and serious Thomas Betterton brought Mary Saunderson honestly to the altar in December 1662. Their marriage license described Betterton as a bachelor, about 30, from Westminster, and Mary as from St Giles, Cripplegate, a spinster, about 25. Interestingly, though Mary was certainly at her own disposal at that age, the license stated that the marriage was with the consent of her widowed mother. The license was dated 24 December 1662, and the couple married shortly thereafter in Islington. There is obviously more to the story, and it is odd that gossipy Pepys did not track it down. Perhaps we may never know why Mary chose to assume Betterton's name for a year or why the marriage was delayed or what part in it all the widow Saunderson may have played, but something happened—a false pregnancy is one possibility that comes to mind—and it may well have had a bearing on Mary's later life.

Mrs Betterton continued playing roles of importance during the years that followed: Queen Catherine in the Davenant version of *Henry VIII* (22 December 1663), Lady Macbeth (again, as altered by Davenant; 5 November 1664), and the title role in Betterton's *The Amorous Widow* (1668–69). When the Duke's players moved to their elegant new Dorset Garden Theatre in 1671 she continued as one of the leading actresses in the company. She was apparently well liked by audiences, and most especially by Pepys, though he seldom went beyond saying that she did a part very well (Cleora in *The Bondman*) or that his "Ianthe" had a sweet voice (apparently Catherine in *Henry VIII*). On the other hand, Mrs Betterton is only once recorded as having delivered an epilogue, at Dorset Garden in September 1677 after *The Siege of Babylon*, so though she may have done well in character, her own personality may not have been attractive enough to warrant giving her such assignments.

She had a flair for teaching, however, and an interest in playing foster mother to young actresses. In December 1674 and January and February 1675 she and her husband trained the courtly performers for the production of the masque *Calisto*, done in March. Mrs Betterton's chief responsibility was teaching Princesses Mary and Anne (later Queen Anne) and Mrs Jennings. Anne was later to remember this kindness in a pension granted Mrs Betterton. In the late 1660's, probably, the childless Bettertons took young Anne Bracegirdle into their home when Anne's father fell on hard times; they apparently treated her as their own child and doubtless helped prepare her for her stage career. In 1692 they repeated this gesture with Elizabeth Watson, daughter of Sir Frederick Watson, who lost his own and Betterton's fortune in a commercial venture in the East Indies; the Bettertons generously adopted Elizabeth, who eventually married the actor John Boman. Mary Betterton's interest in helping others continued long after her own acting career ended, for after the turn of the century her chief function in the theatre was training the younger performers.

In the later 1670's Mrs Betterton played three more roles indicative of her talent. On 11 March 1676 she created Belinda in *The Man of Mode*; in January 1678 she was Evandra in Shadwell's version of *Timon of Athens*; and in April 1679 she was cast as Andromache in Dryden's *Troilus and Cressida*. These parts, like Ophelia and Juliet, suggest her penchant for playing the sweet young girl or good woman; yet at the other extreme stand Lady Macbeth and the Duchess of Malfi, dynamic and tormented females. In between was such a role as Elvira in *The Spanish Friar*, done 1 November 1680, which Dryden may have written with Mrs Betterton in mind. The playwright described Elvira as "of middle stature, dark-coloured hair, the most bewitch-

ing leer with her eyes, the most roguish cast! her cheeks are dimpled when she smiles, and her smiles would tempt a hermit." So the actress had a talent for coquette roles, too. As she grew older she moved into such parts as the Queen Mother in *The Massacre at Paris* (7 November 1689) and the Duchess of York in *Richard III* (1690–91).

Though she may have preferred playing good women or witty sophisticates, she was apparently best as Lady Macbeth. Colley Cibber, remembering her as she was in about 1690, made some very revealing comments about her in this role:

> Mrs. *Betterton*, tho' far advanc'd in years [she would have been about 53], was so great a Mistress of Nature that even Mrs. *Barry*, who acted the Lady *Macbeth* after her, could not in that Part, with all her superior Strength and melody of Voice, throw out those quick and careless Strokes of Terror from the Disorder of a guilty Mind, which the other gave us with a Facility in her Manner that render'd them at once tremendous and delightful. Time could not impair her Skill, tho' he had brought her Person to decay. She was, to the last, the Admiration of all true Judges of Nature and Lovers of *Shakespear*, in whose Plays she chiefly excell'd, and without a Rival. When she quitted the Stage, several good Actresses were the better for her Instruction.

After the Duke's and King's companies joined in 1682, Mrs Betterton was apparently used less and less, and by December 1694 when Betterton started proceedings that led to his setting up a second company to rival Christopher Rich's at Drury Lane, she apparently stopped acting and assumed a semi-retired position in the troupe. Her last two recorded roles (though she may have played others that the sparse records do not show) were Wishwell in *The Maid's Last Prayer* at the end of February 1693 and Ximena in *Love Triumphant* in mid-January 1694. She signed the list of grievances her husband drew up against Rich, though she registered no specific complaints herself; when the Drury Lane patentees replied to Betterton's protest, they noted that Mrs Betterton had been receiving £10 weekly for acting, £6 weekly as her share of the rent and 50*s*. weekly, apparently for training the younger actors. But, they complained, "She not appears in any pts to y^e^ satisfaction of y^e^ audience."

Mary Betterton's position in the United Company during its last years must have been awkward. She was apparently past her prime as an actress, yet she held major roles which some of the younger members of the troupe aspired to. As Betterton's wife she was the first lady of the company—and continued to be so listed even after she gave up acting—so her salary was indeed higher than she probably deserved. After Betterton formed his own company to act at Lincoln's Inn Fields and later at the new Queen's Theatre in the Haymarket, Mrs Betterton remained on the roster, apparently, but was gradually reduced in rank and salary; a Public Record Office document showing "An Establishm^t^ for y^e^ Company," undated but probably about 1705–1707, shows her at the bottom of the list of women, designated as "Housekeep^r^ & to teach to act" at a fixed salary of £80 annually—about half what Mrs Bracegirdle and Mrs Barry were paid.

How all this may have affected Mrs Betterton can only be guessed. Davies, writing later in the century, described her as a woman "of a thoughtful and melancholy temper" who was "rather a prudent and constant than a fond and passionate wife," and Cibber noted that she "was a Woman of an unblemish'd and sober life." Her famous husband died on 28 April 1710, apparently intestate and poverty-stricken. On 2 May 1710 the *Tatler* revealed that she had

> long pined away with a sense of [Betterton's] decay, as well in his person as his little fortune; and, in proportion to that she has her-

self decayed both in her health and reason. Her husband's death, added to her age and infirmities, would certainly have determined her life, but that the greatness of her distress has been her relief, by a present deprivation of her senses. This absence of reason is her best defence against age, sorrow, poverty, and sickness.

Queen Anne granted Mary Betterton a pension (though it was apparently not paid her before her death), and the players, in addition to having paid her £1 weekly over the years as a pension, gave her a salary of £25 during the 1710–11 season and a benefit on 4 June 1711—but in her pitiful state she may have been unaware of these kindnesses. By 10 March 1712 she had regained her reason and she then wrote her will. In it she described herself as of the parish of St Martin-in-the-Fields, a widow, and "weak in body" (she was about 75). Among her bequests were £20 to her sister Mary Head, £5 each to her nephew John Williamson and her niece Mrs Anne Harrison, £5 to her husband's sister Mrs Mary Kelly (though she called Mrs Kelly her niece), and 20*s.* each for mourning rings to her friends Mrs Bracegirdle, Mrs Barry, Thomas Doggett, Robert Wilks, Mrs Anne Betterton and her niece Flint, to be paid out of the arrears of the pension from the Queen. Her niece Frances Williamson, wife of John, was named executrix and given the bulk of her estate, including her "dear husbands picture."

Soon after this, Mary Betterton died. She was buried on 13 April 1712 in Westminster Abbey, beside the body of her husband. In an age when lampooners castigated nearly every other performer, including her sober husband, she escaped unscathed; but the information we have about her personal life and stage career hint at wounds of a deeper sort. The odd circumstances surrounding her marriage, the adopted children and the interest in teaching, the qualities she brought to Lady Macbeth, her natural introversion in an age of extroverts, the later years of apparent uselessness and decay, the childless marriage, and her tragic madness—all suggest an inner life austere, possibly guilt-ridden, perhaps loveless, and truly pathetic.

**Betterton, Thomas William** *d. 1834, actor.*

Thomas William Betterton was the son and grandson of sextons of St Andrew's Church, Dublin, named Butterton. For obvious professional reasons he changed his name to that of the great Restoration actor. He first came before the public in 1778 when he played in the company managed by Myrton Hamilton in the new Ann Street Theatre in Belfast. He must have been already in the company for several months when, on 21 December 1778, he married an actress of the troupe, for on 9 January 1779, while they were at Newry on the Belfast circuit, their daughter Julia was born. Betterton's bride was the "Widow Palmer," according to W. J. Lawrence. But W. S. Clark records no "Widow Palmer" in the Belfast company in this or any other year. It may be supposed that Lawrence meant Mrs James Parker, widow of the previous manager, who was an actress with the company. Parker had died in 1778.

Lawrence believed that the meaning of Tate Wilkinson's remark that Betterton "had squandered a little fortune at Newry and other towns in Ireland" was that he probably did so "in building the Hill Street theatre" in Newry in 1783. Lawrence does not suggest where the fortune was obtained. But the Bettertons were indeed again at Newry in 1784. They were engaged at Edinburgh in 1785–86 but left in March to join Wilkinson's organization on the York circuit. They were still, or again, at York in 1788–89. Betterton was a favorite there, praised extravagantly by the local press for his easy, manly deportment and good looks. The couple's son Peter, three months old, died in York and was buried at All Saints Pavement on 23 Febru-